



KEY

- No impact
- Low impact
- High impact

THIRD TRIMESTER	WHEN TO STOP
Listen to your body and slow down if need be.	You can continue swimming until the birth.
Change to a recumbent bike if you feel uncomfortable.	Stop if you feel too tired or get dizzy.
Try other alternatives unless your doctor says it's safe to continue.	Stop when you feel too tired and heavy.
Find out which equipment is safe to use. Continue pregnancy classes.	Stop if you feel too tired or get dizzy or light-headed.
Check with your doctor that it's safe to continue hiking.	Stop if you feel too tired or get dizzy or light-headed.
Focus on relaxation and breathing techniques.	Continue with gentle Pilates until the birth.
Listen to your body and slow down if you feel tired.	Continue walking until the birth.
Don't lie flat on your back after 16 weeks or you may feel faint.	Continue with gentle yoga until the birth.
Try low-impact options unless your doctor says it's safe to continue.	Stop if you feel too tired or get dizzy or light-headed.
Try low-impact options unless your doctor says to continue.	Stop if you feel too tired or get dizzy.

Q Will having sex affect the baby at all?

There is no medical evidence to suggest that having sex if your pregnancy is straightforward will harm your baby in any way—it's perfectly safe for you to enjoy sex in each trimester.

Neither is there any risk of miscarriage or premature birth when you have penetrative sex. Once you become pregnant, your baby is well protected: your cervix is sealed with a thick mucus plug, and as the fetus grows, the amniotic fluid around it helps to cushion it from any pressure. If you have complications, however, such as heavy vaginal bleeding or your water breaks, you are advised not to have sex and should seek medical attention straight away.

Increased libido

Making love during your first trimester shouldn't feel any different physically, but if you are nauseous or chronically tired, you may have a low libido. If you've had a previous miscarriage or assisted conception, you and/or your partner may feel nervous about having sex. Reassure each other and cuddle to maintain your intimacy until you want to make love.

During the second trimester, your body changes shape noticeably, which can make some women feel less sexually attractive. However, you should have more energy, feel more relaxed about the baby's safety, and find your libido has returned: the increase in blood volume in your body can heighten sensations, and help you reach orgasm more readily. If you feel your baby moving after sex, it may be due to the adrenaline release you receive at orgasm.

During your third trimester, you may have Braxton Hick's contractions if you reach orgasm and these can last from a few minutes to half an hour afterward, which is normal. However, if the contractions continue longer and you are concerned, contact your doctor.

Q I can't stop thinking about the birth. How will I handle labor, and motherhood?

It's hard not to leap ahead and think about the future, but as your body changes and the baby grows your emotional mindset will evolve. Your hormones are already responding to the new life inside you and gradually preparing and

Taking a pregnancy exercise class provides more than just physical rewards: it's a great way to meet other, like-minded moms-to-be to share your experiences and enjoy making some new friends.

enabling your body to give birth, but it can be hard for your thought processes to fall in line with your natural instincts. Your well-being is of paramount importance so that you are in the best possible shape physically and mentally to give birth and take care of a baby. For now it's good to focus on the present and how best you can take care of yourself and the fetus. Keeping fit, eating healthily, and avoiding stress, anxiety, and fear are key. Try to relax and unwind as much as possible, talk to your doctor about any concerns you still have and, as much as you can, be aware of the miracle of pregnancy and how your baby is growing.

Q I'm still in shock about being pregnant. Will I ever get excited and enjoy my pregnancy?

If you feel that you can't shake off your state of shock, be reassured. The first few weeks are an unusual time as you battle to cope with the onset of early pregnancy symptoms, wonder about the future, and yet see no real evidence of a baby. Sometimes negative feelings arise partly as a result of having to keep it all a secret for a while. As you open up about your news, and start to feel physically better, the shock should dissipate. Do positive things to make your experience of pregnancy as enjoyable as possible: pamper yourself with relaxing baths and massages, sleep in when you can, plan events to look forward to, and enjoy closer bonds with family members and friends and enjoy their excitement and good wishes, for example. If the feelings of shock or fear don't subside, talk to your doctor to ensure you don't have the condition tocophobia: a fear of pregnancy and childbirth.